before it developed into World War I.

The war made little sense to the nations of Eastern Europe. It was not their war, although, as it dragged on, they realised that it might represent an opportunity for their national aspirations. Some of the Eastern European nations were in quite a complex situation. While the Austrian-occupied part of Poland became the centre of the movement to restore the Polish state, part of the country was also under the rule of Russia, one of the Allies in the war. Some in the Polish national movement thought that they could somehow, perhaps by playing the Slavic card, achieve (limited) independence with the help of Russia. At the same time, many Western Allies thought that Russia should not be upset by the idea of a Polish state but that the Poles should be left in the Russian zone of influence. Things became more complicated for the Poles with the Communist revolution in Russia when Lenin went on to sign a separate truce with the Central Powers. (A few decades later, Stalin would do something similar with Hitler.) The Western Allies were also concerned that a social revolution might spread from Russia (something, as we shall see, would worry European powers for the entire interwar period), which is why an independent Polish state came to be seen as a welcome buffer zone.[39] In the Czech and the Slovak lands there was also a pro-Western and a pro-Russian strand within the national movement.

In the very last months of the war, Eastern European nations, one by one, proclaimed their independence from the Austro-Hungarian Empire (and from Prussia). They were encouraged by American involvement in the war and, above all, by President Wilson's Fourteen Points, the most important of which acknowledged the right of national self-determination. Although there were conflicting interpretations of what exactly President Wilson meant by this, it marked the beginning of the love-affair of Eastern Europe with America at a time when the 'old' Europe was not able to sort out its own problems.[40]

Sometimes only indirectly, Russia played an important and positive role in the independence struggle of a large number of Eastern European nations. (Although the Slovenians and the Croats, for example, were not really affected by Russia.) For a time it appeared that perhaps even the long-standing conflict with the Poles could be resolved. All this was suddenly brought to a halt by the Soviet revolution and soon a rather sinister Soviet